



AFTER

The Civil War transformed fundamental aspects of the postwar South, leaving the region impoverished and politically weak compared to the rest of the country.

THE NEW SOUTH

The Civil War brought an end to slavery and Reconstruction would give **further rights and freedoms to former slaves** (see [The Reconstruction plan](#)). Free-labor relations replaced slavery, and Black people received a share of the returns for their work. "Sharecropping" allowed laborers to work the lands of others for a share of the crop. **The South would remain mainly agricultural** but railroad development, manufacturing, and urbanization would increase dramatically (see [The Reality of Black Freedom](#)).

The wealth of this "New South" went largely to Northern investors or white Southern merchants and businessmen. For white and Black people at the bottom of society, the **postwar years were marked by poverty**. Beset by crop failures, white owners of small farms found themselves **increasingly reliant on cotton to pay debts**. But overproduction lowered prices and indebted the farmers. The main consequence was the **loss of political influence**—not to return until the 20th century.